near his house was a R&AW spotter and his driver had been especially recruited to report on his activities. He often preached the wisdom of the Bhagavad Gita to his son and daughter, both settled in the USA. Was this a conscious attempt to cleanse himself of the sin of betraying his country? Or was he the perfect example of a person who defended and sold his country in same breath?

Even before the birth of the R&AW, India's only spy organisation, the Intelligence Bureau (IB) had been on the lookout for traitors and peddlers of valuable information, including government servants who handled sensitive files. There were rules for identifying and isolating such suspects. For instance, one kept an eye on anyone staying at the office during odd hours, anyone making extra copies of documents, being inquisitive about matters with which she or he was not directly connected, unauthorised absences from office, leave at regular intervals or on fixed days, bad habits, drunkenness and living beyond their means.

Intelligence organisations believe that weakness in character often prompts a person to barter official secrets for money or other considerations. The rulebook said: 'Musings with suspected persons or those who have certain political affiliations should be avoided to prevent leakages. The wide range of governmental activity and the increased complexities of administration have greatly added to the number of those who possess information, which must be safeguarded. Precautions are needed not only to prevent foreign powers from obtaining unauthorised information but also to avoid disclosure, which might bring improper financial or commercial advantage to people outside the government service.'